

Kiyomizu-dera Temple

Location Kyoto, Japan

Kiyomizu-dera Temple is among the largest and most important of the many Buddhist temples in Kyoto, which, until 1868, was the imperial capital of Japan. It stands in an extensive complex of buildings on a rocky, wooded hillside overlooking the city. The temple was founded in 798 but most of the current buildings were rebuilt after the originals were destroyed in a fire in 1633. The main hall, or *hondo*, of the temple itself was built in honor of Kannon Bodhisattva, the Goddess of Mercy. The structure is cantilevered over a precipitous slope and supported by substantial timbers. Above this is a large terrace under sweeping roofs set at right angles to each other. The heart of the temple is aglow with brilliantly gilded images.

Shugakuin Imperial Villa

Location Kyoto, Japan

The chief glory of the Shugakuin Imperial Villa is not its architecture—which is

harmonious, simple, and modest—but its gardens, which extend over the rocky, heavily wooded foot of Mount Hiei. There are three principal buildings: the Upper, Middle, and Lower villas. The Upper and Lower villas were built between 1655 and 1659, and the Middle villa in the 1680s (as a nunnery). Apart from the Middle villa, the gardens and buildings were the work of the former emperor Go-Mizunoo, who, in 1629, stood down in protest at the constricting power of the Tokugawa Shogunate (military government). The dominant feature of the overall design is a large man-made lake. Rock-strewn streams and ponds criss-cross the well-maintained mossy gardens. The mood throughout is contemplative and calm.

Citadel of Bam

Location Bam, Iran

In December 2003, the Citadel of Bam (or Arg-é Bam) on the high desert plateau of southeast Iran was largely destroyed by an earthquake. Until its sudden destruction, it had been the largest walled, mud-built city in the world, dominated by its fortress. However, what has since been rebuilt makes its former magnificence clear. The site

covers 1,940,000 square ft (180,000 square m), and its walls are 6,000 ft (1,815 m) long. There had been a settlement at this natural oasis since the 6th century BCE, but the citadel's much later importance stemmed from its access to the Silk Road to the east and the Persian Gulf to the south. Its importance reached a peak under the Safavid dynasty, which came to an end in the early 18th century.

Shwedagon Pagoda

Location Yangon, Myanmar

Yangon's Shwedagon Pagoda may be the most instantly stupefying building in the world. The date of its construction is uncertain, but according to legend, it is up to 2,500 years old. The most sacred of Myanmar's Buddhist shrines, it is said to contain a collection of holy relics. It is a stupa—a moundlike structure, typically with a hemispherical dome, topped by a spire. The stupa was a major Buddhist contribution to the architecture of India and later of Southeast Asia. It is a design rich in symbolism, the base and summit representing Earth and the sky, respectively. Several stupas were built across what is today Myanmar. The exterior of the Shwedagon Pagoda is covered entirely in gold, and in the top of the spire—which rises to 325 ft (99 m)—are set thousands of precious stones, including a single 76-carat diamond. The main pagoda is surrounded by 64 smaller spires.

Genbaku Dome

Location Hiroshima, Japan

Just as the shattered tower of the 19th-century Kaiser Wilhelm Memorial Church in Berlin stands as a stark reminder of the city's devastation by Allied bombing during World War II, so do the ruins



of the Genbaku Dome. Also called the Atomic Bomb Dome and the Hiroshima Peace Memorial, it stands as a memorial of the destruction of Hiroshima by the first atomic bomb, in August 1945. Opened in 1921 as the Product Exhibition Hall, it was the only building left standing in the center of the city after the bombing. The decision to preserve it in its ruined state, as the centerpiece of the Hiroshima Peace Memorial Park, was made in 1950. It has periodically been discreetly reinforced to ensure that it remains intact.



◀ THE NIOMON GATE OF KIYOMIZU-DERA TEMPLE, GUARDED BY TWO LION DOGS